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CHALLENGE 6
THE SAFETY QUESTION

Was the Ahmedabad crash waiting to happen? Aviation experts warn against rushing to conclusions as the black box analysis is still under way. International experts say the GE GEnx engines, which power the aircraft, have an excellent safety record. Others, however, do not rule out dual engine failure or pilot error. Boeing has come under intense scrutiny in recent years over its safety record. The crisis can be traced back to the two fatal 737 MAX crashes in 2018 (Java Sea) and 2019 (Ethiopia), which together claimed 346 lives and were linked to a flawed flight control system. Subsequent investigations exposed a corporate culture accused of prioritising profit over safety. The situation escalated in January 2024, when a door plug blew off an Alaska Airlines 737 MAX mid-flight, prompting temporary grounding of over 170 jets and a sweeping audit that uncovered "multiple instances" of lapses in quality control.

The Ahmedabad crash is widely being viewed as a wake-up call—with Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran himself terming it a "catalyst" for building a "safer airline". Aviation safety consultant Mohan Ranganathan believes Air India's safety oversight has not yet really "matured" under the Tatas. The new management may have imposed stricter compliance, but some observers feel that the crash provides a key lesson: as aviation scales up, safety governance must keep pace.

"The crash also reinforces a broader industry learning seen in previous cases like the Boeing 737 MAX. That is, production and operational pressures can erode safeguards," says Pragya Priyadarshini, managing director of Primus Partners, a management consultancy firm. It highlights the need for airlines and regulators to independently verify the manufacturer, as well as maintenance work, strictly enforce maintenance standards and encourage a culture where flight crews can report issues freely without fear of consequences, she adds.

CHALLENGE 7
REFURBISHING ITS DENTED IMAGE

For an airline now under the umbrella of a well-known conglomerate, passengers expect better safety and service standards from Air India. "A crash like this inevitably dents public perception," says D.P. Hemanth, CEO of the Asia Pacific Flight Training Academy. "People might now think twice before choosing Air India on similar long-haul routes when they have options."

To be fair, the Tatas have in the past three years tried to introduce sweeping upgrades—from physical and IT infrastructure to a wholesale rejuvenation of staff. The voluntary retirement of 6,000 employees paved the way for onboarding fresh staff with new skills and capabilities. Air India now has a staff strength of around 18,000. The average age of the non-flying staff was 54 when the Tatas took over; now, it is 35. For cabin crew, the average age was in the high 40s; it is now 29. Moreover, as much as 35 per cent of the widebody aircraft have been upgraded.

Jitender Bhargava believes the best way to move beyond the tragedy is to look at how other major airlines survived such crises. "Did they shut down operations or slow down the pace of growth? If not, why should Air India be different? It is India's biggest global player," he says. "Will you judge an airline's safety track record with one accident? The answer is no." Take Air France, for instance. After the crash of Flight 447—an Airbus A330 that went down in the Atlantic in 2009, en route to Paris from Rio de Janeiro, killing all 228 people on board—the airline responded to the intense global scrutiny with transparency and reform, not retreat, retaining public trust and continuing to grow.

For all of its missteps, some experts argue, air safety isn't Air India's burden alone. Kapil Kaul, CEO of CAPA India, believes it is time for India to have "institutional accountability" as far as air safety is concerned, for which a "strong regulator is key". "It is not just about the airlines, but the entire system," he adds, which includes air traffic control, airports, training and MRO activities.

June 12 will be remembered as one of the "darkest days" not just in the Tata Group's history, as Chandrasekaran described it, but in Indian aviation as a whole. There can be no compromise on safety in a rapidly expanding aviation market. The Tatas themselves can take the lead in committing unequivocally to world-class safety standards to build the global airline they envision. ■